

Ocean products

PEOPLE HAVE ALWAYS HARVESTED plants and animals from the ocean. Many different animals are collected for food, from fish, crustaceans (shrimps, lobsters), and mollusks (clams, squid) to more unusual foods, such as sea cucumbers, barnacles, and jellyfish. Seaweeds are eaten, too, either in a recognizable state or as an ingredient of ice creams and other processed foods. The products made from sea creatures are amazing, although many (such as mother-of-pearl buttons and sponges) now are replaced by synthetic materials. Yet the appeal of natural ocean products is so great that some sea animals and certain kinds of seaweeds are cultivated. Among sea creatures to be farmed are giant clams (for pretty shells), mussels (for food), and pearl oysters. Farming is one way to meet demand for products, and to avoid overcollecting the ocean's wildlife.



Yarn dyed purple from pigment of sea snails

ROYAL PURPLE

Sea snails were used to make purple dye for clothes worn by kings in ancient times. Making dye was a smelly process, as huge quantities of salted snails were left in vats gouged out of rocks. The purple liquid was collected and heated to concentrate the dye. These sea snails (from Florida and the Caribbean) are used to make purple dye.

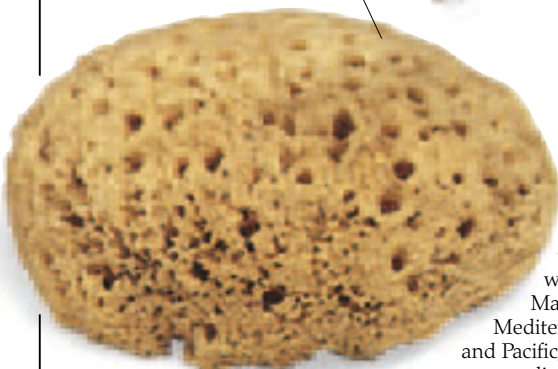
Slate-pencil sea urchin from tropical coral reefs in the Indo-Pacific

Short, blunt spines surround mouth

Long, very strong spines help protect urchin from predators

Five, strong white teeth protrude from urchin's mouth (viewed from underneath)

Soft skeleton left after processing living sponge



SOFT SKELETON

Bath sponges, harvested from the sandy seabed, grow among sea grasses in reef lagoons. When brought up from the bottom, the sponges are covered with slimy, living tissues. Mainly collected from the Mediterranean, Caribbean, and Pacific, natural sponges are prone to diseases and overcollecting.

USEFUL SPINES

The spines of this urchin were once used as pencils to write on slate boards. Slate-pencil urchins are still collected, their spines used for wind chimes. Hung from threads, the spines clink together when the wind blows through them. Urchins use their big spines to help them walk across the seabed, when they emerge from crevices to feed at night.

Spines help urchin move and to hold it in place

SEAWEED FARM

In Japan, seaweeds are used in crackers and to wrap raw fish parcels. Red seaweed is grown in the sea on bamboo poles, collected, and dried. Laver, a similar kind of red seaweed, is eaten in Wales, UK. Made from red seaweeds, agar (a jellylike substance) is used in foods and in medical research. Seaweeds are also used as fertilizers.

